Imbibing certain intrinsic values, the most fundamental amongst which was to be a good human being, was a part of growing up. My spiritual study is anything but profound but there are certain endearing universal values of Sikhism that guide me during difficult times.

Sikhism was founded and evolved by Guru Nanak in the fifteenth century. It evolved as a distinct faith with its own cultural and physical identity and ideology through the teachings and legacy of ten gurus till the end of the seventeenth century. The term Sikh is derived from shishya, a Sanskrit word meaning a disciple or follower. A majority of Guru Nanak's disciples were from the peasantry of Punjab, the fertile 'land of five rivers' lying between the rivers Indus and the Sutlej. His followers were from both the dominant religions of the times, Hinduism and Islam, mainly because of the simplicity of his message, and its appeal to humanity. Guru Nanak was always accompanied by two of his ardent and highly devoted followers, one of whom was a Muslim named Mardana, a proficient rebaab[1] player, while the other was Bala, a Hindu.

Deeply etched in my mind is Guru Nanak's philosophy based on the three basic precepts of 'naam japo', 'kirat karo' and 'vand chako'. The first enables man to link all dimensions of life to the omnipresent God, and helps him purify his mind and heart and face the vicissitudes of life with courage and fortitude. The second exhorts the Sikhs to balance the spiritual and physical aspects of existence, and live a full life with a sense of creativity and dynamism, while remembering God. The third envisions a social order in which one shares the God-given bounties with others in a spirit of love and service.

When the guru's end was near, as a story recounted in Khushwant Singh's comprehensive and authoritative *History of the Sikhs* puts it: 'Said the Mussalmans: "we will bury him"; the Hindus: "we will cremate him; Nanak said: "You place flowers on either side, Hindus on my right, Muslims on my left. Those whose flowers remain fresh tomorrow shall have their way." He asked them to pray. When the prayer was over, Baba pulled the sheet over him and went to eternal